

SACHIN TENDULKAR

34, CRICKETER (30)

STILL NOT OUT

BECAUSE 18 years on, he is still India's most bankable blue-chip batsman, scoring over 1,100 runs in Tests and 1,200 in ODIs in the last 12 months. Because, as the Australian team discovered his word counts like little else in world cricket. Because at 34, he is batting like he was 25, logging in 27,000-plus runs and 80 international centuries for India at the turn of the year. Because even though short-sighted newspaper headlines regularly predict the onset of "End-ulkar", he is not going anywhere yet. Because his dealings with the IPL's Mumbai franchisee Mukesh Ambani and his role in that most expensive team will be worth following.

QUIETEST ENDORSEMENT:

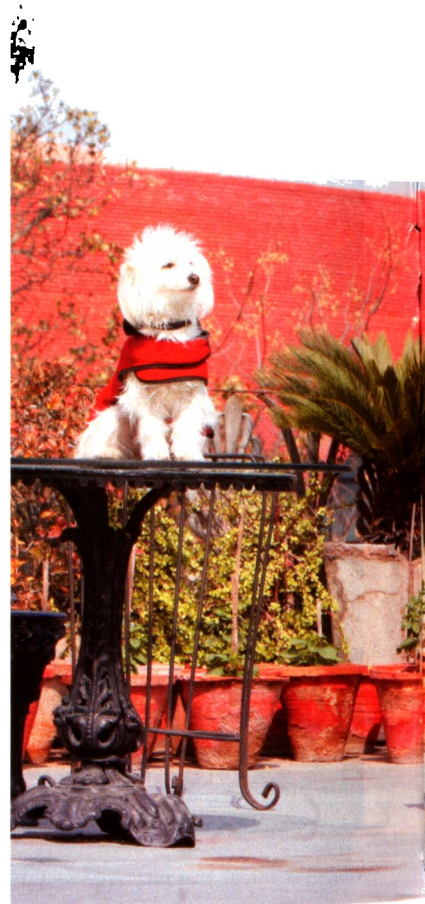
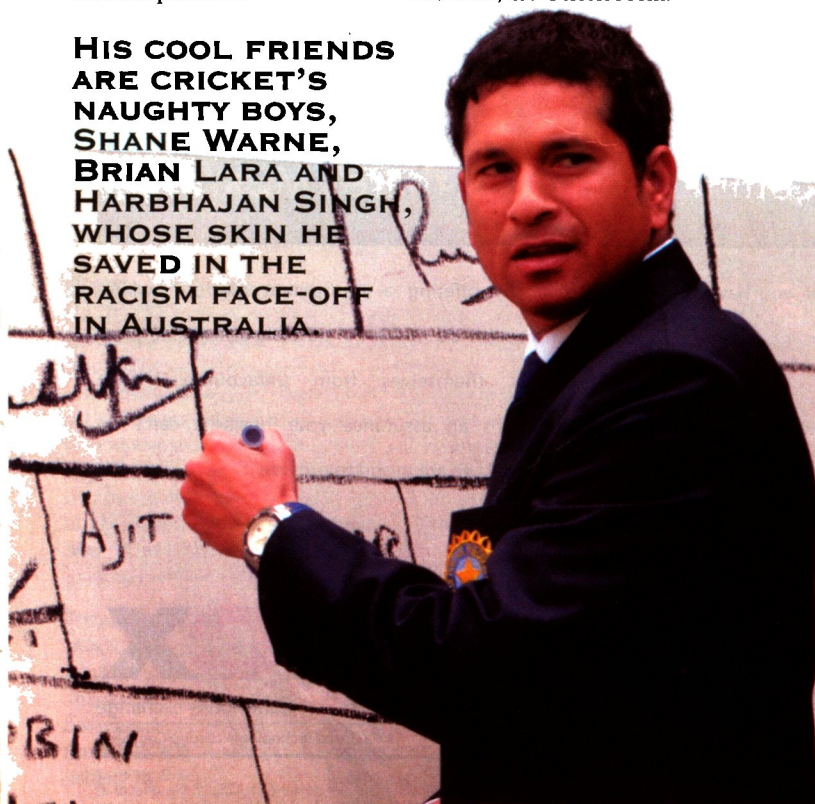
Is the brand ambassador for legendary Swiss watchmaker Audemars Piguet. He occasionally sports a piece said to be worth about Rs 35 lakh.

THORN IN HIS SIDE: Statistical nit-pickers trying to puncture his champion cult.

STRANGE BUT TRUE: Other than batting, he's a natural left-hander. Watch him sign autographs.

IS PARTICULAR ABOUT: Never leaving his bats along with the rest of his kit at the ground. The bats are sequestered, along with him, in his hotel room.

HIS COOL FRIENDS ARE CRICKET'S NAUGHTY BOYS, SHANE WARNE, BRIAN LARA AND HARBHAJAN SINGH, WHOSE SKIN HE SAVED IN THE RACISM FACE-OFF IN AUSTRALIA.



ONE ARGUMENT HE CANNOT WIN: With his wife. When she does anything wrong, it is karma. When he makes a mistake, it's his fault.

BIG ACQUISITION: A pair of rottweilers. Says he's "behaving himself and not buying a new car".

HE SUCCEEDED IN THWARTING THE GOVERNMENT'S EFFORTS TO HAVE THE STAY VACATED IN THE RESERVATIONS CASE.